



KEEPING THINGS IN PERSPECTIVE | EXERCISE 1

Develop The Ability to Keep Things in Perspective

The following exercise - for individuals or groups - is based on The Six Thinking Hats principle, a concept developed by Edward de Bono. Applying this method can be instrumental in maintaining perspective. This offers a structured approach to thinking and problem-solving by considering different perspectives through the lens of 6 hats.



BLUE HAT

Conductor

Organisation & Planning,
big picture perspective,
action plan



WHITE HAT

Reason

Facts, figures,
information



BLACK HAT

Devil's Advocate

Risks, Consequences,
Difficulties, Roadblocks



GREEN HAT

Creative Thinker

Creative thinking, new
ideas, out-of-the-box
thinking



RED HAT

Instinctive

Feelings & Instinct



YELLOW HAT

Optimistic

Benefits & Values

Key strategies for achieving a better outcome:



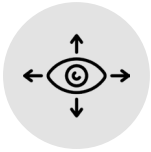
Structure your discussion so that all participants collectively explore the problem using each of the Six Thinking Hats.



Have everyone focus on the same hat simultaneously to promote parallel thinking rather than adversarial.



Resist the urge to criticise or dismiss ideas; instead, concentrate on generating creative alternatives.



KEEPING THINGS IN PERSPECTIVE | EXERCISE 1

Maintaining Perspective

Conduct a debrief or post-mortem analysis of a project, error or challenging situation - for individuals or teams.

Utilise the Six Thinking Hats method to structure a comprehensive review of a completed project. Following the template below, assess the project's overall outcome and identify key takeaways, highlighting both strengths and areas for improvement.



A specific challenge or problem faced by an individual or team

Combine different perspectives to establish an Action Plan

Where are we now?
What conclusions can be drawn?
What do we do next?
Who needs to do what?



Focus on facts, data, information related to the issue.

What information do I/we have?
What do I/we know to be true?
What information do I/we need to obtain?



Feelings & Instinct

How does this make me/us feel?
What is my heart/gut telling me/us?
What feels right/appropriate?
What is making me/us feel this way?



Benefits & Values/potential positive outcomes

Why is this a good idea?
Why and to whom is this valuable?
Possible benefits /advantages?
How can I/we make this work?



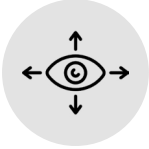
Risks, Consequences, Difficulties, Roadblocks

Why won't this work?
What problems could this cause?
What are the drawbacks/risks?
Will this create challenges & for whom?



Creative thinking, Out-of-the-box solutions

What haven't I/we thought about?
Are there any alternatives?
How can I/we change or improve this?



KEEPING THINGS IN PERSPECTIVE | EXERCISE 1

Maintaining Perspective - Carrying out the Exercise

- 1 Present a specific challenge or problem faced by an individual or team.
- 2 Establish the Order, always starting and ending with the Blue Hat, for example: Blue (planning the discussion), White (gather information about the issue), Red (emotions and gut feel), Yellow (positive outcomes), Black (negative outcomes), Green (creative ideas / alternative solutions), Blue (decision/ action plan).
- 3 Allow time for everyone to collect their thoughts and make notes on the template.
- 4 Set a Time Limit (generally 10 minutes), for each hat so that the time is shared between the hats, allowing extra time if the discussion is going well for a particular hat.
- 5 Explain the Exercise, outline its purpose, the situation/ decision/problem, set ground rules and what you want to achieve by the end of the exercise.
- 6 Open the floor for discussion. If doing this as an individual make notes on each perspective, OR if it's a team discussion the leader needs to keep the discussion on task and capture everyone's input using a whiteboard, or sticky notes if in person (use Google docs or Canva whiteboards if virtual).
- 7 Work through each Hat.
- 8 Return to the Blue Hat- draw conclusions, learnings, and assign any actions from the exercise.



You can use this method to make decisions, develop ideas, and carry out post-mortems.



KEEPING THINGS IN PERSPECTIVE

The Six Thinking Hats Technique

Edward de Bono's 'Six Thinking Hats Technique' can be used by individuals or groups to work through everyday situations using 6 different thinking styles.

This will allow you to approach and evaluate challenges from all possible perspectives, resulting in more accurate, creative, and original solutions or ideas.

It can also be used to carry out post-mortems on many aspects of work, such as individual or group projects, presentations, customer meetings.

Applying this method in the workplace can be instrumental in maintaining perspective and also encourage collaboration, critical thinking and creative problem-solving.

The Blue Hat: Organisation & Planning/ Big picture perspective – this hat controls everything and represents structured thought. It is used to decide which hats you're going to put on and the order. And it is used at the end to make a decision by pointing out alternatives, suggesting new strategies, maintaining control and focus, and finally to translate the thinking of all the hats into actionable steps.

The White Hat: Information Gathering – this perspective is objective and logical. It looks for concrete facts by gathering and analysing the available information from an objective, neutral and unbiased point of view.

The Black Hat: Risk Assessment – consider the potential consequences if you act solely on your instincts – all the reasons something won't work. This represents the logical-negative side including considering the risks, pitfalls, consequences, difficulties, and drawbacks, drawing on past experiences and shows you why certain things might go wrong or not work. This will guide you to become more realistic, to try new things, and not repeat past mistakes.

The Green Hat: Creative Thinking, New ideas – are you overlooking anything? – encourages lateral thinking encompassing originality, creativity, crossing boundaries, out-of-the-box solutions, making the impossible possible.

The Red Hat: Feelings, Emotions, Instinct and gut feeling – encourages you to consider the situation in an intuitive, passionate, emotional, and subjective way without the need to explain or justify. It also helps you understand other's emotions and needs.

The Yellow Hat: Benefits & Values – what opportunities or benefits could arise from the proposed course or courses of action? – this represents the logical-positive side. Still ruled by logic, but by being constructive and optimistic, you will explore benefits and opportunities in the problem/decision/task at hand that others may not.